

PORTAL HYPERTENSION

One of the complications of liver cirrhosis is portal hypertension. As the tissue becomes progressively scarred and fibrosed, it obstructs the flow of blood into the liver from the portal vein, a large vessel carrying blood from the digestive tract. Pressure builds up in the vein, and can cause other vessels “upstream” to become distended. Among these are veins in the abdomen and rectum, and those that supply the oesophagus with blood. The swollen veins, or varices, protrude into the oesophagus and may bleed. In some cases, only slight oozing occurs. In others, a major haemorrhage causes massive vomiting of blood. Not everyone who has liver cirrhosis develops portal hypertension and

oesophageal varices. In those who do develop the condition, the varices can be treated with drugs to reduce the blood pressure or injected with a sclerosing (hardening) agent, much like that used to treat varicose veins.

